

Introduction to the 1993 Edition

Discovering jazz, as the Czech writer and jazz-buff Josef Skvorecky has said, is, for most people, rather like first love—on the whole it is more lasting—and it usually happens at much the same time. In the case of the present writer it happened at the age of sixteen, in the year Adolf Hitler took power in Germany. My family had just returned to England after a few years in the movie business in Berlin, and a losing struggle against the slump. My old man brought back a copy of Carl Laemmle's biography by John Drinkwater, a forgotten but on this occasion evidently well-paid minor English literary figure, personally signed by Uncle Carl—and practically no money. Until we could find a suitably cheap apartment, we stayed with relatives in Sydenham, a Victorian white-collar suburb in Southeast London.

My aunt Cissie, living in undefined detachment from Uncle Lou, who was permanently absent pursuing business across the Atlantic, taught school. Her married daughter, also living in the same house, was trying to teach dancing and elocution to the daughters of aspiring mothers in the neighborhood. Her husband was not making a living and was therefore uncommunicative. The one member of our host-family who seemed to be a human being in the full sense of the word was a young man of my own age, my cousin Denis Preston. We had known of one another before, because our families—this is the way of families—had told us to write letters to each other. There had been a half-hearted correspondence between London and Berlin, from which both sides concluded that the other guy was a drip. When we actually met, we were agreeably surprised to find that the other guy was OK. I undoubtedly tried to convert him to communism to which I had been converted while living through the rise of Hitler. He converted me to jazz.

How he had come to jazz I don't know, but in retrospect it is not surprising. He conformed exactly to the type of the 1930s British jazz fan which is sketched in the chapter on the 'jazz public': the intelligent, self-educated young man from the lower middle classes, preferably a little

bohemian. (My cousin had dropped out of high school and was studying to be a viola player.) Jazz, of course, meant exclusively the few 78 rpm records the British companies released every month which had to be sorted out from the larger mass of contemptible dance-band noises to which they were attached. Still, there was by then a small British public for jazz and even a reliable guide to what was good, Spike Hughes in the *Melody Maker*, my cousin's bible. My cousin bought these, played them until the grooves groaned and, when money was short (it usually was) made a part-exchange deal with the local record shop. At any time he was likely to have perhaps twenty of these heavy black discs, in brown paper or cardboard covers—sleeves were a generation away.

These were the records we played in a sparsely furnished attic, on the heavy hand-cranked box which in those prehistoric days was not even yet called a record-player but a gramophone. In between records and intensive discussions about how great they were, we restored our strength with potato crisps and spoonfuls of heavily sugared canned milk, the kind that was firmly labelled 'unfit for babies'. We preferred to have these sessions at night. When the days were too long, we drew the curtains.

In retrospect, the jazz we came to through these British releases of the early 'thirties, was as good an introduction to the music as any that was available. The first jazz records I remember were the Fletcher Henderson band's ('Sugar Foot Stomp', 'House of David Blues'), Don Redman's ('Chant of the Weeds'), the Mills Blue Rhythm Band, Bix and Tram, of course, the Mills Brothers—I wonder how that ancient vocal group stands up to rehearing—and the accepted geniuses, Armstrong and Ellington. The Armstrongs we heard were not yet the *Potato Head Blues* Hot Fives and Hot Sevens, but how could we complain when the Armstrong-Hines combinations, *St James Infirmary*, *Knockin' a Jug* and *West End Blues* were already available? And, fortunately, the great man had not yet been tied up in the strait-jacket of New Orleans archaeology. Though we sighed over the commercial corruption of true art in records like *Confessin'* and *Song of the Islands*, we were lucky to be introduced to a great artist at the very peak of his form. As for Ellington, could anyone hearing *Black and Tan Fantasy* and *Creole Love Call* not be captured for life?

Then Ellington came in person. He was, by this time, a composer taken seriously by the hipper sections of the British musical establishment. He was also a greatly appreciated figure in the younger aristocratic and even royal circles, which probably pleased him at least as much. Two suburban teenagers, who belonged to neither of these groups, could only express their devotion in a suburban way. We made the pilgrimage to the Streatham Astoria in South London, a ballroom where the band was booked for what was then called a 'breakfast dance', midnight to morning. (Of course we knew the great man's record *Breakfast Dance* forwards and backwards.) I assume our elders had pity on us, because the tickets were far beyond our normal financial reach.

There we sat, from midnight till dawn, nursing the glass of beer which was all we could afford, the image of the band burning itself on our brains forever. Maybe, after almost sixty years, I can no longer without prompting recite the entire personnel of Ellington 1933, including Ivy Anderson whose *Stormy Weather* was the hit of the season (as with the other women singers of the band, except Adelaide Hall of the unforgettable *Creole Love Call* we could live without them), but to this day I can see Hodges, impassive as what in those politically uninformed days we used to call a Red Indian, stepping forward to wind his sounds round our hearts. We walked home four miles in the dawn—the money had run out—and I was hooked for good.

For the next twenty-odd years, like most British jazz fans, I subsisted on records—on the old, heavy, three-minute shellac 78s, because a dispute between the two musicians' unions kept American musicians out of Britain. (We were convinced that only Americans, preferably black, were worth listening to.) In this stored and unreal form the music was available, at least to the network of aficionados, sufficiently small for everyone to know somebody who supplemented the excellent selection of commercial releases by importing discs directly from the United States. It was an artificial situation, though it gave the core group of British fans a considerable influence over the development of the music in Britain. Since they virtually controlled what they heard, they were the taste-makers. To take the most obvious example: The first kind of live native jazz that developed on any scale, from the later years of the war onwards, was that typical phenomenon of collectors and fans, the Dixieland

revival. However, whereas Lu Watters and Bob Wilber were peripheral to the U.S. jazz scene, the British revival bands were absolutely central to it. These bands, largely recruited from amateurs, in turn took over from the original aficionados a passion for the country and city blues, some of which had come to Britain via the American communist and radical repertoire of the black folk-protégés (Leadbelly, Brownie McGhee, Sonny Terry, Josh White et al.), and some via the small but passionate groups whose collectors' hearts had always been in Clarksdale rather than New Orleans. As I point out in the 1989 Introduction, a lot of British rock music's ability to capture the world was due to the fact that the average white British 18-year-old was much more likely to have heard Muddy Waters than the average white U.S. teenager.

The downside of this state of affairs was that the British jazz authorities (like most of those who had developed their taste in the 1930s, notably the French) were taken aback by bebop and to be honest, most of them disliked it intensely. It came, not out of the milieu of enthusiastic and, in general, musically illiterate appreciators, but of young professional big-band musicians. (The young British band musicians were much more receptive to bebop, but theirs was a very small scene.) It was a revolution, and European jazz fans didn't need one or want one. They wanted 'authenticity'. Moreover, the wartime recording ban in the U.S.A. broke that continuity of record releases that got even unadventurous fans used to thinking the spectacular transformations of jazz between, say, 1926 and 1941 (few arts have changed more rapidly) not as a series of revolutions in the *avant-garde* manner, but as just growth. After all, the Pope of the Church of Jazz Tradition, Hugues Panassié himself, who denounced the 'modernists' as agents of Satan, had found neither Lester Young nor Charlie Christian unacceptable. The bop revolution caught Europe unprepared, although in suitable countries (notably France and Scandinavia), a new generation of intellectual champions of the *avant-garde* soon appeared. They were rewarded by the expatriate U.S. bop players who settled there in the desert years.

During all these years I had been no more than a fringe observer of the jazz scene. I was no expert. I was neither a collector nor the sort of guy whose name collectors knew, and I neither wanted to write about jazz nor did anyone ask me to. Not even in any of those tiny, short-lived,

fact-filled, and denunciatory jazz magazines in which the experts poured out their information and squared up to each other on such issues as black vs. white or the acceptability of swing bands, like entrants for a local amateur bantamweight contest. Through my cousin (who eventually went into the recording business), I knew these people and learned from them, for every jazz expert was and is a passionate educator. But though I also educated others, I was no specialist. From the jazz point of view I had only one peculiarity which made me noticeable: I was (by the 1950s) a professional historian.

Why this should have struck both jazz and non-jazz people as so bizarre, I still find difficult to understand. Academics who were passionate jazz lovers were a minority but not at all unknown, even in my own generation, the university graduates of the 1930s. It is true that the sounds preferred in the groves of academe were closer to Beethoven than to Basie, and that the new generations of students had not yet begun to flood into universities by the hundreds of thousands, at least in Europe. (When they did, they brought rock with them rather than jazz.) It is also true that most of the substantial but growing academic jazz underground kept their unofficial musical tastes to themselves or shared them only with sympathisers, like dissident sexual or gastronomic inclinations. And yet, profoundly as the cultural atmosphere has changed since the 1950s, a historian who also writes about jazz is still considered in many quarters as freaky, in some way, through attractively so. To have written about professional soccer, or to have been a successful race-horse tipster, or a well-known compiler of chess problems, or a passionate gambler—I am citing real cases—has not become part of the image of the academics who pursue these extra-curricular activities—but to have written a book about jazz has, at least in my case. What's so odd about the combination of jazz and history? Perhaps readers can explain what the author cannot.

So I got into jazz writing because editors and publishers enjoyed the idea of a professor reporting (in those days pseudonymously) on such unacademic music. Conversely, the idea of being reported by a *bona-fide* Ph.D. for *The New Statesman*, which was at that time the ranking guardian of British high culture, tickled people in the British, and later the American, jazz scene. The middle fifties were an ideal time to start writing about jazz. For the first time Brits could regularly hear first-rate

American artists live, and shortly after, not without some complications from those who guarded America against red subversion, I began to visit the U.S.A. Meanwhile both musicians and serious jazz-buffs were abandoning the pointless battles between Rampart Street and 52nd Street: all except the comic novelist Kingsley Amis and the poet Philip Larkin, who continued to see bebop as treason. Larkin even wrote an uncharacteristically sentimental poem about Bechet, full of French Quarter clichés.

I wrote that column for about ten years until remarriage and small children produced a major clash between the nocturnal timetable of a jazz writer and the daytime life of a family man. Eighteen of these columns from 1955–65 are reprinted for the first time in this edition. When jazz started to revive in the 1980s I began to write about it again, in a different and more reflective manner, stimulated by the good luck of living and working within walking distance of *Bradley's* and the *Vanguard* in New York for part of the year. The Introduction to the 1989 British reprint of *The Jazz Scene*, which the present edition reproduces, tried to bridge the gap that separated the jazz of 1960 from that of 1990. Meanwhile Robert Silvers of *The New York Review of Books* gave me the chance to meditate again on why jazz is not only a marvellous noise but a central concern for anyone concerned with twentieth-century society and the twentieth-century arts. These five studies of the jazz revival of the 1930s and the 1980s, and of particular jazz artists in their social context—Ellington, Basie, Bechet—are essentially about the interaction at one particular moment of American history, between the makers of jazz, the self-contained democracy of professional working musicians, the 'community of night people with folk roots,' and the fans who recognized that they were witnessing the birth of art. These pieces are, I hope, logical extensions of the original *Jazz Scene*.

So, one way or another, this book is one person's reaction to sixty years' experience of jazz. (Sixty years? You must be joking. I wish I were). Where, after all those decades, during which the writer has survived most of those he wrote about and too many of those to whom he owes his jazz education, does jazz stand at the end of the century?

The jazz revival I surveyed in *The New York Review* in 1987 has lasted on both sides of the Atlantic, though hit by the Depression of the

early 1990s. In November 1991, *Hot House*, the 'Jazz Nightlife Guide' distributed in the New York area, listed forty-one clubs and halls playing the music in Manhattan that month, plus another thirteen in New Jersey. The number of these venues was still rising, but rather slowly. And yet, there was something strange about this revival, even though that strangeness made it more familiar to such ancient jazz-lovers as the present author. The jazz of the early 1990s looked back.

Suppose we look at the *Downbeat Critics Poll* of 1991, which lists as its 'Jazz Artists of the Year' Wynton Marsalis, Benny Carter, Sonny Rollins, Jackie McLean, Dizzy Gillespie, Cecil Taylor, Henry Threadgill, and David Murray. Five of these eight were household names in 1961, two came up in the hard years of jazz exile and are now middle-aged, and only Wynton Marsalis (a second-generation jazz-man) belongs to the 1980s. The *Readers Poll* (December 1990) is not noticeably fixture-oriented, though it gives more space to middle-aged talents who paid their dues in the dark years (Jack de Johnette, Marcus Roberts, Phil Woods, Pat Metheny).

Suppose we look at what they play. The basis of what is played today is essentially what was played in the 'forties and 'fifties. Every one is a bopper. It is not that nothing has been happening in jazz since then, but rather that the innovations of the past thirty years, from free jazz to fusion, have been silently marginalized. Even the most enthusiastic obituaries of Miles Davis, the key figure in the development of jazz since the early 1950s, grow noticeably more ambiguous about his last twenty years and prefer to keep quiet about his last ten. This suits senior citizens who have no trouble remembering the marvels of the first Quintet, of *Miles Ahead* and *Kind of Blue*, but surely the generation gap should not look quite so narrow? 'Tradition' is the key word now, a term once heard more often among jazz fans deploring the end of Dixieland and their youth, than among musicians. And yet, here is a twenty-five-year-old sax player ('out of Parker and Adderley') as recently reported:

Bird is the main influence because he covers so many eras and styles in his playing. He stood for the tradition and I figured if I studied enough Bird I'd get hold of it.

Did Bird think of himself that way when he was twenty-five?

Indeed, the *mode retro* goes back along way beyond the original boppers. There has been a return to the standard ballads, even if they are now played with *avant-garde* flourishes by men returned to the mainstream from the more inaccessible frontiers, like Archie Shepp, the terror of the 1960s. There are even signs of the black rediscovery of the original New Orleans tradition, which I predicted in *The Jazz Scene*, admittedly from Wynton Marsalis, who is both from New Orleans and a man in favour of traditions. There has been, above all, an extraordinary return to the blues. Last year's reissue of Robert Johnson is said to have sold 500,000 copies. Benson and Hedges sponsors a Blues Festival in New York. Blues bars are opening right and left in Chicago, to the deserved benefit of old men who could do with a buck or two, and, as I write, they are being imported into a new New York club advertising nothing but Chicago blues.

All this is both comforting and familiar to old-stagers, though it is impossible today to feel, as we did in the later 1950s and in the years from 1936 to 1942, that we are living through a golden age of jazz again. There is just a lot of jazz to listen to, and no shortage (at least in the New York area) of piano-players who are both adventurous and accessible. But it is also a danger sign. Jazz cannot survive like baroque music, as a form of pastiche or archaeology for the cultured public, even among blacks. But this is precisely the danger that threatens it. Black kids do not sing the blues today. They are performed, at best, by elderly artists for elderly neighborhood audiences and, at worst (as in many of the new Chicago blues rooms), in *white* neighborhoods, by the same grey-heads, for white students. Black kids do not dream of playing horns (except, paradoxically, among young Caribbeans in Britain, who have no indigenous jazz tradition), but of being in great rap groups; a form of art which, in my opinion, is musically uninteresting and literary doggerel. In fact, it is the opposite of the great and profound art of the blues. There are good reasons for this—what is one sax compared to the ghettoblaster?—but it cuts off the roots of jazz. The flourishing black media and art scene—what might be called the Spike Lee belt—is impregnated with jazz and so, obviously, are musicians black or white. But jazz has always lived not by the hipness of the public (which has, with the rarest exceptions,

always been a minority public), but by what Cornel West calls ‘the network of apprenticeship’, the ‘transmission of skills and sensibilities to new practitioners’. The cords of this network are fraying. Some of them have snapped.

Is jazz then being transformed beyond redemption into another version of classical music: an accepted cultural treasure, consisting of a repertoire of mostly dead styles, performed live by artists—some of them young—for a financially comfortable middle-aged and middle-class public, black and white, and the Japanese tourist? Will it be, once again, accessible to its potential mass constituency basically through radio and recordings, as it was to my European generation half a century ago? To listen to most jazz stations today is to be back in the esoteric world of those who have the true faith, where three days devoted *exclusively* to, say, recordings of Clifford Brown are seen as three days well spent.

Is jazz becoming terminally fossilized? It is not impossible. If this should be the fate of jazz, it will not be much consolation that Clint Eastwood has buried Bird in a celluloid mausoleum and that every hairdresser and cosmetics store plays tapes of Billie Holiday. However, jazz has shown extraordinary powers of survival and self-renewal inside a society not designed for it and which does not deserve it. It is too early to think that its potential is exhausted. Besides, what is wrong with just listening and letting the future take care of itself?

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